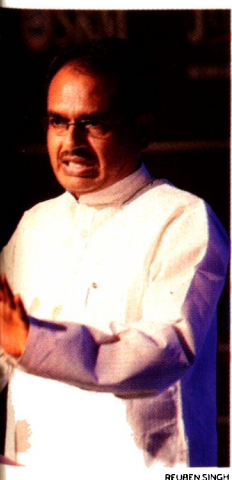
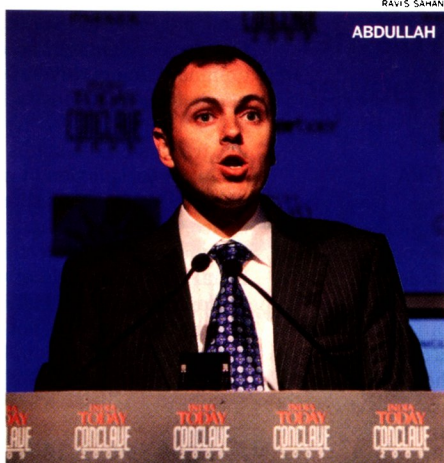


(BELOW, FROM LEFT)
INDIA TODAY EDITOR
PRABHU CHAWLA
WITH SHIVRAJ SINGH
CHOUHAN, ASHOK
CHAVAN AND
OMAR ABDULLAH



REUBEN SINGH



RAVIS SAHANI

well as Parliament be held simultaneously at the end of five years so that governments can concentrate on the welfare of the people for the next four-and-a-half years at least. In the last three years that I have been the chief minister, I have fought elections nearly 13 times. Every four to six months, we have a by-election and if we lose the election, the media says that the government is about to fall. To ensure that the government doesn't fall, we keep preparing for the elections. I would also like to advocate that people be allowed to elect the prime minister and the chief ministers. An individual who is popular among the masses will take over as the prime minister and be able to govern for the next five years or we will have a coalition government that may last two or three years.

“For the states to deliver, give us autonomy”

OMAR ABDULLAH

CHIEF MINISTER, JAMMU AND KASHMIR

I may be the youngest chief minister but I represent a state and a political party that's the oldest advocate of states' autonomy. We have a historical, constitutional and political basis for this claim. I believe the time has come when the original form of autonomy in Jammu and Kashmir needs to be seen, not just as an aberration or an accommodation, but as a model for all other states in the Indian federal system. In other words, the autonomy envisaged for Jammu and Kashmir could and should become

the rule rather than exception in the Indian federal system.

Having said that the larger question is if there is a generic case for enhancing the autonomy of the Indian states. And I believe there is. To deliver change on the ground but also to prevent the national political system from imploding, there are compelling systemic reasons to revisit the issue of autonomy of the state to seemingly unrelated changes. Regularisation and decentralisation have over the years disempowered the state governments by eroding their policy making space.

In the last two decades, the nature of Indian polity has undergone a sea change. Not only is there a coalition at the Centre but there are different parties and coalitions in power at both the Centre and in the states. The regional parties are tying up with one or the other main national party to increase their leverage at the Centre. But this is not the systemic solution. The need for the systemic solution arises from the fact that under such a situation the logic of federation undergoes a change. In such a situation the cooperative federal system that has been envisaged by the founding fathers of the Constitution, which has already become competitive federalism in a negative sense, and it is fast heading towards cohesive federalism. If the nation has to be stable and strong, the structural imbalance has to be addressed. The only way to do it is to give more autonomy to the states which is in line with the democratic trends reflected in the growth of regional parties. The only way to ensure stability in the system is operational political decentralisation.

Once that is done, genuine economic decentralisation will follow. What form should this autonomy take? First, the new framework of the Centre-state relations must be designed for an open economy that is driven by the private sector rather than the public sector. Economic liberalisation has caused huge regional imbalances between states. The gap in the per capita income across states is widening, but the states have no instrumentality to address these or such imbalances.

Change is the latest buzzword. People want to see change and they don't want to have to wait for it. Especially, geographically and infrastructurally challenged states like mine can't deliver that quantum of change without a healthy dose of autonomy—fiscal as well as political economy. And so in a nutshell, I would say yes, in order to deliver change, states must receive a healthy dose of autonomy.